When to Take the List Out Again

Family and ownership changes worth writing down while Dad is well, with no judging what any of them means.

The list of what Dad owns is accurate today. Families change, accounts get opened and closed, and it's hard to know which changes are worth a note.

This guide names fifteen everyday changes worth noticing while Dad is well and, for each, what to write down. Notice and record. Don't interpret. What a change means for the questions about his house and savings is for your Medicaid planner or an elder law attorney to say, and a dated note is what makes that conversation useful. A few items carry a general explanation from a public source, marked with a number; the choice of what to notice and the wording about what to write down are ours.

Family

1 A marriage, a divorce or a death

NOTICE A change in who Dad is married to, or the death of his spouse, a child, or anyone whose name is on his accounts or his papers.

WRITE DOWN What changed, and the date. If you know which of his papers name that person, list them.

2 Who lives in the house

NOTICE Someone moving in with Dad or moving out: a grown child, a grandchild, a companion.

WRITE DOWN Each person's name, how they're related to Dad, and since when.

3 Who helps Dad with money [1]

NOTICE One of you starting to pay his bills, keep an eye on his accounts or sign things for him, and any paper that was signed to allow it.

WRITE DOWN Who helps, with what, and under what arrangement. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau suggests reviewing a choice like this every so often, so add the date you last looked at it.

Health and daily life

4 A change in Dad's health

NOTICE A new diagnosis, a stay in the hospital, or a doctor raising the subject of help at home.

WRITE DOWN What happened and the date, in one line. You aren't judging what it means for his care, only noting that it happened.

5 Regular help with everyday things [2]

NOTICE Dad starting to get regular help, from family or from someone paid, with things he used to do himself. Long-term care, in the federal long-term care site's glossary, means services and supports necessary to meet health or personal care needs over an extended period of time.

WRITE DOWN Who helps, with what, how often, and since when.

6 Talk of a move

NOTICE Dad or the family talking about a smaller place, moving in with one of you, or somewhere with more support. Also anything he says about what he'd want done with the house.

WRITE DOWN What was said, who said it, and when. Use his own words where you can.

The house and other property

7 A sale or a purchase

NOTICE The house going on the market, a second property or a piece of land bought or sold, a car or anything else of real value changing hands.

WRITE DOWN What it was, the date, who it went to or came from, and where the papers are.

8 A change to the deed

NOTICE A name added to the deed or taken off it, or a new deed signed for any reason.

WRITE DOWN The names exactly as printed, before and after if you have both, the date, and who prepared the paper.

9 A loan against the house

NOTICE A new mortgage, a refinancing, or a line of credit that uses the house.

WRITE DOWN The lender, the date, and where the papers are kept.

Accounts and beneficiaries

10 An account opened, closed or moved

NOTICE A new account, an old one closed, or money moved from one bank or company to another.

WRITE DOWN The bank or company, the date, and in one line where the money came from or went.

11 A name added to an account, or taken off [1]

NOTICE A change in the title at the top of a statement: Dad alone, Dad and his spouse, Dad and one of the children. In a joint account the money is jointly owned, so every name is worth copying.

WRITE DOWN The title exactly as printed, before and after, and the date of the statement you copied it from.

12 A beneficiary form

NOTICE A beneficiary named or changed on a retirement account, an insurance policy or a bank account, or a form you've only now come across.

WRITE DOWN Who is named, on what, and the date on the form. If nobody can find the form, write “form not found.”

13 A gift or a transfer

NOTICE Money or property Dad gives to a child, a grandchild or anyone else, or something sold to a family member.

WRITE DOWN What it was, who received it, the date, and the amount as best you know. It's a fact for the list, nothing more.

Papers and proposals

14 A will, a trust, a policy or an annuity [3] [2]

NOTICE A new or changed will, the legal document that sets out a person's wishes for their property and belongings. Also a trust set up or changed, a new insurance policy, or an annuity: a contract in which a person gives an insurance company money that is later distributed back over time.

WRITE DOWN What it is, its date, who prepared or sold it, and where the papers are. What it does is a question for an elder law attorney.

15 An offer or a seminar [4]

NOTICE An invitation, a call or a visit proposing that Dad buy a financial product or set up an arrangement, including anything described as “Medicaid safe.” The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau notes that not all titles and credentials for senior financial planning are the same.

WRITE DOWN Who made the offer, their title and company, what exactly was proposed, the date, and any paper they left behind.

When a note isn't enough

For most of these, a dated note is enough. Some call for a person as well. If anyone is thinking of changing whose name is on the house or an account, giving something away, or signing a trust or a new policy, take it to an elder law attorney or a licensed financial professional as a question first. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's guide for homeowners says to seek advice from legal and tax professionals, because transferring property can have significant financial implications. A change in Dad's health, a move, or a death in the family is a moment to take the list out and go over it with your Medicaid planner. If you're not sure where a question belongs, ask your Medicaid planner.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what any of these changes mean, whether anything would be counted for Medicaid, or what Dad may be able to keep. It isn't legal, financial or tax advice. The professionals answer those questions, and they do it better with your dated notes in front of them.

Ready for the next step?

You know which changes to note, and when to take the list out again. The planning interview gives those notes somewhere to go: it asks about your family's situation, one question at a time, and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Considering a financial caregiver? Know your options (Managing Someone Else's Money)
2. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare information), Glossary
3. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Leaving your home to children or heirs (Older Americans Housing Guide)
4. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Know your financial adviser

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From the Medicaid Planning Roadmap · Richard Ladson, Certified Medicaid Planner. Draft for review, generated 2026-10-04.